10

Running Aground

In the midst of unremitting gloom, S.D. Krishna Aiyangar took recourse to issuing more appeals. At the end of 1909, three appeals appeared in the space of a week: on 6, 10 and 13 December. The first one, ‘The Swadeshi Steam Navigation Company. A Rare Opportunity for Indian Patriots’, admitted that only 34,000 of the 80,000 shares had been taken. Further, from the earlier stated requirement of Rs 2 lakh in two months for reviving the steamer services, the demand was pared down to a more modest Rs 50,000 within a month.[1] The next appeal appearing four days later reported that Rs 18,000 in arrears from shareholders and another Rs 8,000 had been collected helping in the discharge of some pressing debts. Krishna Aiyangar renewed his plea to shareholders to pay up their arrears: with the infusion of only Rs 40,000, the *Lawoe* could commence its coastal voyages on 25 December ‘which was bound to bring profit’.[2] But little came of these appeals.

As SSNCo gasped for its last breath, many scurried away deserting a sinking ship. K.R. Guruswami Aiyar, disappeared after the political storm of March 1908 after all the grand statements he had made earlier that year. But a few intrepid directors refused to give up fighting. We are already acquainted with S.D. Krishna Aiyangar and K.R. Venkatarama Aiyar. They were joined by B.K. Ramaier and P.V. Ganapathia Pillai. It is surprising that Ramaier, a member of the Tirunelveli group and auditor of the company, was holding out as he always seemed to be on K.R. Guruswami Aiyar’s side. We know nothing of P.V. Ganapathia Pillai beyond the fact that he was a Tuticorin-based vakil. But their frantic travels, in the last months, speak for their commitment.

Following a meeting of some directors on 15 November 1909, B.K. Ramaier, K.R. Venkatarama Aiyar and P.V. Ganapathia Pillai left for Colombo, triggering rumours that the company was resuming services from